

Free Australian health advice you can count on.

Medical problem? Call 1800 022 222. If you need urgent medical help, call triple zero immediately

healthdirect Australia is a free service where you can talk to a nurse or doctor who can help you know what to do.

 Language displayed in: English



Glossary medical terms

15-minute read



This page lists common medical terms and their meaning.

Skip to content

A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W
X Y Z

A

Active ingredient

The main part of a medicine that makes it work in your body.

Acute

A health problem that begins quickly, is severe and lasts for a short time. For example, an acute allergic reaction to [reaction to peanut butter](#).

Administer

The process of giving or taking [medicine](#). For example, in hospital, paracetamol can be administered by mouth by a nurse.

Adverse event

An unexpected effect from a medical treatment or procedure.

Antigen

A foreign substance, such as a [virus or bacteria](#), that makes the immune system respond.

B



Bacteria

Single-celled living things found everywhere, including in your body. Some bacteria help with natural processes, but others can cause infections.

Benign

A tumour (slow growing cells) on or in the body that is not normal but is usually not harmful. It can grow but it should not spread to other parts of your body.

Biomarker

A biomarker (short for biological marker) can show if disease is in your body. Biomarkers are measured using tests, such as [blood](#) and [urine tests](#).

Biopsy

Taking a sample of a body tissue sample to check for disease. For example, a [skin biopsy](#) involves removing a piece of skin tissue to examine for conditions such as skin cancers.

C

Catheter

A hollow tube used to drain fluids or open passages in your body. For example, a urinary catheter drains urine (wee) from the [bladder](#) if someone cannot urinate on their own.

Cessation

When something stops or when you stop doing something.

Chronic condition

A health problem that is ongoing and long lasting. Examples include [arthritis](#), [cancer](#) and [asthma](#).

Complication

Unwanted short- or long-term effects from medical treatment, such as surgery or medication.

Component

A part of a medicine. Some medicines contain more than one component that you need to take, combine before taking it, or take in a certain order.

Condition

A term used to describe a health problem. For example, a person with a long-term breathing problem has a [chronic respiratory condition](#).

Congenital

Present from birth. For example, some babies have [congenital heart defects](#).

Contagious

An illness that spreads easily from person to person, such as [COVID-19](#).

Contraindication

A reason why a person should *not* have a certain treatment or procedure because it may harm them. For example, people with an [egg allergy](#) should not take medicines containing egg products.

Contusion

An injury that causes [bruising](#), usually without breaking the skin.

Cutaneous

Having to do with the skin. For example, redness on the arm after a [vaccination](#) is a cutaneous reaction.

D



Diagnosis

The process a doctor or other [healthcare professional](#) uses to find out what health condition you have. This may include assessing your health history, doing a physical examination and ordering tests.

Disease

A physical or [mental illness](#) that causes symptoms and signs, and affects how the body works.

Disorder

A disorder is a condition that can change how the mind or body works. This can include mental health disorders and [genetic disorders](#).

Dosage

Instructions on how to take a medicine or treatment. These usually include how much, how often and how to take it.

E

Elective surgery

Surgery planned in advance because it is expected to improve health. It is not done in an emergency.

Epidermis

The outer layer of the [skin](#). For instance, a cream may be put on the epidermis.

Excision biopsy

A surgical procedure to remove something from the body. For example, removing a [breast lump](#) through a small cut.

Existing health problem

Also called a pre-existing condition, meaning you already have a health problem.

Exposure

Contact with a substance by [swallowing](#), breathing it in, or through the skin or eyes. For example, touching body fluids, or inhaling fumes at work. Effects can appear quickly or years later.

I

Implant

A medical device that replaces or improves a part of your body. For example, a surgeon may place a [pacemaker](#) (implant) in your upper chest to help control the rate your heart beats.

Immunity

The ability of your body to fight infection. [Immunity](#) can develop from natural infections or [vaccines](#).

Incision

A cut made by a healthcare professional during a procedure. For example, a surgeon will make an incision in the skin with a scalpel (surgical knife).

Inflammation

Your body's response to injury or infection. Inflammation can appear as redness, heat, swelling and pain. It helps protect and heal the body.

Inhalation

Breathing in. Some medicines are given by inhalation, such as those for [asthma](#) and [COPD](#).



Inpatient

A person formally admitted to hospital for treatment. They may need to stay overnight.

Insulin

A hormone that helps the body use glucose (sugar) for energy. People with [diabetes](#) may need insulin injections to control blood sugar levels.

Intramuscular injection

An injection given into a muscle. Some vaccines are given this way.

Intravenous therapy

Medicine, fluid or blood given into a vein.

Irrigation

Cleaning or flushing out parts of the body, such as wounds or cavities. For example, irrigating a wound to remove dirt.

L**Lateral**

At or on the side. For example, the ears are lateral to the nose.

Life expectancy

The average length of time a person will live.

Lipids

Fatty substances naturally found in the blood and tissues, such as [cholesterol and triglycerides](#).

M**Malignant**

A tumour that can grow and spread fast to other parts of your body. If not treated, malignant cells can cause death.

Medial

Located in the middle. For example, the chest is medial to the arms.

Medicine

Another word for medication. It is used to treat, cure, prevent or relieve an illness, disease or abnormal condition. Examples include over-the-counter products, such as [paracetamol](#) for headache relief, and prescription medication, such as Rosuvastatin to treat high cholesterol.

Membrane

A thin layer of tissue that covers [organs](#) or lines body cavities. For example, the brain is covered by membranes called meninges.

Morbidity

Ill health or sickness. For example, infection can cause morbidity after surgery.

Mortality

Another term for [death](#). It is often used to describe death rates in a community or clinical study.

Musculoskeletal conditions

Relating to your [bones, joints and muscles](#). Examples include [arthritis](#), [back problems](#) and [osteoporosis](#).



N

Negative test results

A test result showing you do not have the condition or substance being checked, or that your levels are normal.

Non-acute care

Healthcare for [chronic conditions](#) to help prevent them from getting worse.

O

Oral

Relating to the mouth. Examples:

- [Oral health](#) is the state of your mouth, teeth, gums and tongue.
- Oral disease includes gum disease and tooth loss.
- Taking medicine orally means swallowing it through your mouth.

OTC (over the counter)

Medicine and treatment you can buy without a prescription from a doctor or other healthcare professional.

Outpatient

Receiving care at a clinic without being admitted to hospital.

P

Physician

Another word for [doctor](#).

Practitioner

A trained professional in a specific field. Medical practitioners include doctors and some nurses. [Allied health practitioners](#) include physiotherapists and optometrists.

Prescription medicine

Medicines you can only get with a prescription from a doctor, dentist or other qualified, licenced healthcare professional. These medicines are only available from a [pharmacy](#).

Prevention

Actions to protect your health now and in the future. For example, [bowel cancer screening](#) and quitting smoking.

Primary carer

The person who gives the most informal help to a person with disability.

Procedure

A surgical or non-surgical action performed by a trained medical specialist, usually using specialist equipment. For example, a [colonoscopy](#).

Prognosis

The likely outcome of an injury, illness or disease.



R

Recent user

Someone who has used [alcohol](#) or other [drugs](#) in the past 12 months.

Rectal

Referring to the rectum, the last part of the [digestive tract](#) (the end of the large intestine) where food waste ('poo') leaves the body.

Relapse

Becoming ill again after recovery. It can also mean using alcohol or drugs again after stopping.

Remission

When signs or symptoms of a disease disappear or reduce. For example, people with cancer often go into remission after successful treatment.

Respiration

Breathing.

Respiration rate

The number of breaths per minute. It is used to check health.

Respiratory conditions

Conditions affecting breathing, such as asthma, bronchitis and [chronic obstructive pulmonary disease \(COPD\)](#).

Respiratory viruses

[Viruses](#) that infect the nose, throat and lungs, and usually cause cold or flu symptoms.

Risk factor

Something that increases the risk of developing a health condition. For example, smoking is a risk factor for [lung cancer](#).

S

Screening

A [health screening](#) uses tests to look for changes or early signs of disease. For example, the [National Bowel Cancer Screening Program](#), which is free. If you take part, you are sent a stool sample kit to check for early signs of bowel cancer.

Signs

A sign is something a healthcare professional observes or measures that suggests you may have a disease or condition. For example, having a [fever](#) can be a sign of infection.

Soft tissue

All the supporting tissues in your body except your bones. This includes muscles, tendons, ligaments, fascia, nerves, fibrous tissues, fat, blood vessels and synovial membranes.

Subcutaneous injection

An injection given under your skin.

Symptoms

What you feel and experience when you are sick. Examples include [abdominal pain](#), fever and diarrhoea.

Syndrome

A set of symptoms that occur together in a health condition, even when the exact cause is unknown. For example, [irritable bowel syndrome](#) is a common digestive disorder that causes abdominal (tummy) pain, bloating and changes in bowel habits.



T

Therapy

Another word for treatment of a medical condition. Therapy can be psychological, physical and medicinal.

Topical treatments

Medicine applied directly to a particular part of the body. For example, eye drops are a topical medicine.

Trachea

The medical term for the windpipe. It is a tube-like structure in the [respiratory \(breathing\) system](#) that connects the larynx (voice box) to the bronchi in the lungs.

U

Underlying cause or problem

The reason behind a health condition or outcome. For example, [chronic fatigue](#) may be caused by an undiagnosed autoimmune problem.

V

Vaginal

Relating to the vagina, which is part of the [female reproductive system](#). For example, a vaginal examination can check for health issues.

Ventricle

A ventricle is a chamber or cavity in the body. There are 2 main types in humans:

- [Heart](#) ventricles — the 2 lower chambers of the heart (left and right)
- Brain ventricles — fluid-filled spaces in the brain

Viral infection

When germs (virus) enter your body and multiply inside healthy cells, causing an infection. Examples include the flu (influenza), COVID-19 and chickenpox.

Sources:

Australian Institute of Health and Welfare ([Glossary](#)), Australian Institute of Health and Welfare ([Hospitals Glossary](#)), MS Australia ([Glossary](#)), Northern Territory Government ([Plain English Health Dictionary Aboriginal Interpreter Service](#)), Australian Institute of Health and Welfare ([Treatment complication](#)), National Cancer Institute ([NCI Dictionary of Cancer Terms](#)), Australian Institute of Health and Welfare ([Australia's health 2016](#)), Government of Western Australia Department of Health ([Overview of the WA health system](#)), Australian Institute of Health and Welfare ([Medicines in the health system](#)), Australian Institute of Health and Welfare ([Chronic musculoskeletal conditions](#)), World Health Organization ([Oral health](#)), St John ([Pharmacokinetics](#)), NSW Health ([Outpatient services](#)), Therapeutic Goods Administration ([Prescription medicines overview](#)), Australian Institute of Health and Welfare ([Procedures data cubes](#)), Canadian Journal of Surgery ([How to use an article about prognosis](#)), Cancer council Victoria ([Cancer Dictionary](#)), The Royal Children's Hospital Melbourne ([Acceptable ranges for physiological variables](#)), Sports Medicine Australia ([What is soft tissue injury?](#)), Therapeutic Goods Administration ([Acronyms and glossary terms](#)), Better Health Channel ([Medical procedures - non-surgical](#)), Macquarie Dictionary ([Macquarie Dictionary](#)), Australian Institute of Health and Welfare ([Life expectancy](#)), Royal Australasian College of Physicians ([What is a physician or paediatrician?](#)), Harvard Health Publish Har Medical School ([Medical Dictionary of Health Terms: A-C](#)), National Health and Medical Research Council ([How infections](#)), Cancer Council NSW ([What is a biopsy?](#)), National Library of Medicine ([Medication Routes of Administration](#)), Government



Western Australia WA Country Health Service ([Medication Prescribing and Administration Policy](#)), Department of Health, Disability and Ageing ([Australian Immunisation Australian Immunisation Handbook Glossary of technical terms](#)), Peter MacCallum Cancer Centre ([Brain cancer](#))

Learn more here about the [development and quality assurance of healthdirect content](#).

24 hour health advice you can count on ☎ 1800 022 222



We are a government-funded service, providing quality, approved health information and advice



Healthdirect Australia acknowledges the Traditional Owners of Country throughout Australia and their continuing connection to land, sea and community. We pay our respects to the Traditional Owners and to Elders both past and present.

© 2026 Healthdirect Australia Limited